

Final Criteria List: Writing Compelling, Lean, Online Learning Content

1. Focus: Purpose

- ☐ States a clear purpose upfront (Answers 3 questions: What is this about? Who is it for? Why is it important?)
- ☐ Intended audience is clear (effort is made to tailor content to that audience).
- ☐ Provides a WIIFM for the target audience (What's in it for me? What are the benefits to reading?).
- ☐ Clearly presents a main idea or thesis and supports it throughout the piece.
- ☐ Learning objectives or outcomes (if stated) are clear, measurable, and appropriate to audience level.

2. Captures and Sustains Attention

- ☐ Captures the reader's attention with a strong opening (intriguing headline, attention grabbing first line, quote, anecdote, or thought-provoking question).
- ☐ Opening "hook" focuses on the benefit to the reader.
- ☐ Evokes emotion. Creates an emotional connection with the learner.
- ☐ Offers an element of 'novelty' to distinguish the topic or approach as 'new and exciting'.
- ☐ Content fulfils the promise of the title.
- ☐ Triggers and feeds curiosity through use of questions or inquiry rather than solely imparting information.
- ☐ Leaves room for thought. Learner has 'voice' & 'choice' in content or action. Answers are not obvious.
- ☐ Embeds "epiphanies" (little 'aha' moments) throughout for continuous learning.
- ☐ Creates linkages with what the learner already knows (helps relate to existing schema).
- ☐ Storytelling is used where appropriate to bring content to life and make it relatable and memorable.
- ☐ Humour is used if/where appropriate to boost mood, activate interest and aid in retention.
- ☐ Sustains the reader's attention to the conclusion (strong ending restates thesis/WIIFM & fits the focus).
- ☐ Content & structure propels reader forward (makes them keep reading to know what happens next).

3. Organization

- ☐ Content is structured into short, digestible topics or 'bite sized chunks' of information.
- ☐ Topics are sequenced into a logical flow.
- ☐ Self-explanatory topic headers/subheaders are used to organize content and help with 'skimming' & 'scanning' of content. Improve readability and search engine optimization.
- ☐ Main ideas are united and well-developed with smooth transitions between paragraphs and sections.
- ☐ Prioritizes for impact: puts the most important content first.

4. Credibility

- ☐ Information provided is credible and inspires confidence in claims.
- ☐ Content is strengthened by facts, expert opinions, or links to additional sources.
- ☐ Draws on stories, examples or metaphors current & relevant to the reader (not predictable/stereotypical)
- ☐ Effectively integrates research and source material as required with proper citation.
- ☐ Offers sources that represent more than one viewpoint (may include contrasting arguments or outside thinking)

5. Language

- ☐ Sentences employ clear and plain language.
- ☐ Addresses the reader directly: "I'm talking to YOU" (Note: "we/us" may be desired when speaking 'universally' to avoid confronting the reader)
- ☐ Language is current, inclusive, gender neutral and culturally sensitive.
- ☐ Active voice is used for power and clarity – and uses present tense.
- ☐ Tone or "voice" is inviting, authentic and appropriate for the audience and subject matter.

- ☐ Pays attention to diction and word choice (power verbs, concrete nouns, spare use of adjectives & adverbs)
- ☐ Eliminates repetitive, weak and redundant words.
- ☐ Avoids use of jargon and “business speak”.
- ☐ Sentences are crafted with attention to variety in length and punctuation.

6. Engagement

- ☐ Stimulates curiosity & critical thinking: causes the learner to pause, reflect, check understanding, or consider scenarios or past and future actions.
- ☐ Encourages action: Includes elements of interactivity where reader must actively do something with the content right now, or provides a challenge or call to action for the learner to apply learning moving forward (what’s next?).
- ☐ Employs sensory integration (visuals, audio, touch, etc.) with various media and modes for learning.
- ☐ Incorporates exploratory elements that allow learners autonomy to discover the content on their own.
- ☐ Provides opportunities for learners to provide feedback or personal insights, or to share and discuss.

7. Conventions

- ☐ Follows conventions of proper grammar, spelling, punctuation, and capitalization (proofread is evident)
- ☐ Reading is smooth and easy; content is free of fragmented and run-on sentences.

8. Format

- ☐ Text and visuals have an inclusive, professional and appealing layout, look and feel.
- ☐ Visuals, graphics and media enrich and extend meaning; are illustrative, not merely decorative.
- ☐ Meets format recommendations for print/online text including: size, fonts, and colours.
- ☐ White space is employed to give the reader places to pause and breathe.
- ☐ Leverages layering/linking ability of online formats to include resources, pop-ups and additional information.
- ☐ Navigation is simple and intuitive.
- ☐ Standards for accessibility and principles of Universal Design Learning are employed.

9. Style

- ☐ There is a clear personal and unique style to the writing, suited to the audience and purpose.
- ☐ There is evidence of original thinking and creativity applied to the topic.
- ☐ Length of topics allows for the reader to move through at a satisfying and appropriate pace.